

What are Opinions? Integrating Theory and Methods for Automatically Analyzing Opinionated Communication (OPINION)



WORKING GROUP MEETING

COST ACTION CA21129 OPINION, 11-12 June 2024

University of Salamanca

CONTENTS

1	VENUE	2
2	PROGRAM	3
3	PRACTICAL INFORMATION: Before the meeting.....	5
4	PRACTICAL INFORMATION: During the meeting.....	6
5	PRACTICAL INFORMATION: After the meeting	9
6	PARTICIPANTS	11

1 VENUE

For this Working Group Meeting, we are guests of the University of Salamanca. Our host is Prof. Carlos Arcila Calderón at the Faculty of Social Sciences.



The meeting will take place at the F. E. S. Building of the Miguel de Unamuno Campus, which is located on Paseo Francisco Tomás y Valiente St, 37007 Salamanca, just West of the historical center.

The campus is adjacent to the Salamanca Bus Station, and only a short walk away from the city center. The closest bus stop is Avenida Doctor Ramos del Manzano, which is served by bus number 7 that runs to the Salamanca railway station, and bus number 13 to the city center. The map below shows the meeting venue relative to the recommended hotels and main transportation hubs.



2 PROGRAM

Tuesday, 11 June 2024

09:00-09:30 *Arrival & Coffee*

09:30-10:00 **Welcome Plenary**

Room: Adolfo Suarez Events Hall

- **Welcome** – *Christian Baden, Carlos Arcila Calderón*
- **Introduction of Project Space & Workshop Sessions** – *hosts*
- **Practical issues** – *Carlos Arcila Calderón*

10:00-12:30 **Working Group Sessions I** (*parallel sessions*)

Theory	Tools	Data & Application	Dissemination & Inclusion
Room 003A <i>Chair:</i> <i>Nicoleta Corbu</i>	Room 003B <i>Chair:</i> <i>Damian Trilling</i>	Room 004 <i>Chair:</i> <i>Hajo Boomgaarden</i>	Room 005 <i>Chair:</i> <i>Carlos Arcila Calderon</i>

12:30-13:30 *Lunch at the Café-Restaurant of the Faculty of Law*

13:30-15:30 **Project Space & Workshops** (*parallel sessions*)

Any initiatives beyond the listed sessions will be able to meet in an additional open space.

“Team 5”	Computational Literacy	Measuring LLMs’ “opinions”	Hackathon Planning Meeting
Room 003A <i>Host:</i> <i>Aleksandra Krstic & Dimitra Milioni</i>	Room 003B <i>Hosts:</i> <i>Ema Kristo, Edlira Gugu, David Herrero Blanco & Carlos Arcila Calderón</i>	Room 004 <i>Host:</i> <i>Aleksandra Urman, Johannes Gruber & Valerie Hase</i>	Room 005 <i>Host:</i> <i>Christian Baden</i>

15:30-16:00 *Break / Time for Projects*

16:00-18:00 **Working Group Sessions II** (*parallel sessions*)

Theory	Tools	Data & Application	Dissemination & Inclusion
Room 003A <i>Chair:</i> <i>Agnieszka Stepinska</i>	Room 003B <i>Chair:</i> <i>Damian Trilling</i>	Room 004 <i>Chair:</i> <i>Hajo Boomgaarden</i>	Room 005 <i>Chair:</i> <i>Carlos Arcila Calderon</i>

18:15 *City Walking Tour (voluntary)*

Afterwards **Working Group Dinner** (*voluntary, self-paid*)

Theory	Tools	Data & Application	Dissemination & Inclusion
Salam Placentinos 10	Corte y Cata Serranos 1	Don Quijote Serranos 28	Corte y Cata Serranos 1

Wednesday, 12 June 2024

09:00-09:15 *Coffee*

09:15-12:00 **Working Group Sessions III** (*parallel sessions*)

Theory	Tools	Data & Application	Dissemination & Inclusion
Room 003A	Room 003B	Room 004	Room 005
<i>Chair:</i> Agnieszka Stepinska	<i>Chair:</i> Damian Trilling	<i>Chair:</i> Hajo Boomgaarden	<i>Chair:</i> Carlos Arcila Calderon

12:00-13:00 *Lunch at the Café-Restaurant of the Faculty of Law*

13:00-14:30 **Masterclass:** (stream) <https://usal-es.zoom.us/j/84629480260>

Room: Adolfo Suarez Events Hall

The Good, The Bad, and The Generated: Opinion Mining with (local) AI
Johannes B. Gruber, VU Amsterdam

14:30-16:00 **Project Space & Workshops** (*parallel sessions*)

Any initiatives beyond the listed sessions will be able to meet in an additional open space.

Theorizing Public Opinion	LLMs as a Tool for Text Analysis	Linguistics Group	Public Opinion in a Digital World
Room 003A	Room 003B	Room 004	Room 005
<i>Host:</i> Christian Baden	<i>Host:</i> Ljubisa Bojic, Anela Mulahmetovic Ibrisimovic & Selma Veseljevic Jerkovic	<i>Host:</i> Barbara Lewandowska Tomaszczyk	<i>Host:</i> Agnieszka Hess, Elena Negrea Busuioc, & Agnieszka Stepinska

16:00-16:30 *Coffee*

16:30-17:30 **Closing Plenary & Wrap-up** (stream) <https://usal-es.zoom.us/j/89072936168>

Room: Adolfo Suarez Events Hall

- **Reports & Updates** – *Working Group Chairs*
- **Expanding the OPINION Universe** – *Christian Baden*

17:30-18:30 **Management Committee Meeting** (*hybrid*)

Room: Adolfo Suarez Events Hall

- The Agenda for this meeting will be emailed directly to all members of the OPINION Management Committee.

3 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: Before the meeting

Travel

Participants are required to make their own travel arrangements, the costs for which will be reimbursed afterwards, subject to the rules detailed below.

The University of Salamanca's Miguel de Unamuno Campus is located West of Salamanca's historical center, next to the Salamanca Bus Station. Regular buses connect Salamanca to Adolfo Suarez Madrid-Barajas International Airport. Buses are operated by Auto-Res, and take about 2:45 hours. Additional buses to Salamanca also leave from Madrid's Auto-Res Bus Station at Méndez Álvaro: www.avanzabus.com

Alternatively, express trains to Salamanca depart from Madrid's Chamartín train station, which take about 1:30 hours, and a regular train service exists from Madrid Principe Pio Station, which takes 2:30 hours: www.renfe.es

The Madrid Auto-Res Bus Station, Chamartín Train Station and Principe Pio Station are all easily reachable from Madrid-Barajas airport by Metro.

There has also been an initiative to share a rental car from/to Madrid-Barajas airport. If you are interested in this, please check the [Google Sheet](#) by Johannes Gruber.

All recommended hotels are within walking distance of the venue.

if you need a taxi, you can book it on +34 923 250 000. <https://www.taxi-salamanca.com/>

Accommodation

Participants need to arrange their own accommodation, the costs for which will be reimbursed afterwards, subject to the rules detailed below.

For participants who require accommodation in Salamanca, we recommend staying at one of the following hotels, which offer decent quality at reasonable cost, and which are within walking distance of the venue (ordered by distance; however, if you choose something different, that is up to you):

- **Zenit Hall88 Studios** (5 min walking): €65 to €120, including breakfast
to book: reservashall88@grupozenithoteles.com +34 923 28 01 88 www.hall88.zenithoteles.com
- **Corona Sol Hotel** (11 min walking): €55 to €100, including breakfast
to book: recepcion@gran-hotelcoronasol.es +34 923 281 616 www.gran-hotelcoronasol.es
- **Arzobispo Fonseca Hostel** (12 min walking): ca. €65
to book: fonseca@usal.es +34 923 294 570 www.colegiofonseca.usal.es
- **Abba Fonseca Hotel** (14 min walking): €72 to €120, including breakfast
to book: fonseca@abbahoteles.com +34 935 153 075 www.abbahoteles.com
- **Artheus Carmelitas Hotel** (16 min walking): €72 to €120, including breakfast
to book: cs@artheushoteles.com +34 923 21 25 00 www.artheushoteles.es
- **Silken Rona Dalba Hotel** (18 min walking): €75 to €120, including breakfast
to book: +34 923 263 232 www.hoteles-silken.com

4 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: During the meeting

Attendance Lists

In order to receive reimbursements for your expenses, you are required confirm your participation via eCOST prior to the event, and to document your participation by signing the attendance list. If you do not sign the attendance list, we will not be able to reimburse you, so please make sure you do not forget this. Please note that separate attendance lists will be available for each day the program, so if you attend the entire duration of the meeting, you will need to sign multiple times.

Wifi

For the duration of the Working Group meeting, you will be able to connect to the *eduroam* network or the network of Salamanca University.

Hybrid Participation / Streaming

The Salamanca WG meeting is an in-person meeting.

Nevertheless, there will be selected sessions that will be streamed for remote participation. Notably, the closing plenary (<https://usal-es.zoom.us/j/89072936168>) and the masterclass (<https://usal-es.zoom.us/j/84629480260>) will be streamed and recorded for later access.

The Working Groups and Project / Workshop Sessions may decide to offer hybrid participation at their own discretion.

Project Collaboration / Workshop Sessions

To facilitate the formation of collaborations among members of the network, the program includes time dedicated to project collaborations. This is time that you can use to work on your current collaborations with other network members, or to meet other members and come up with new ideas for collaboration.

The following table gives an overview over the planned Project / Workshop Sessions. Please note that some sessions are open for anyone who wants to join, while others are not looking for new members; if you are interested in joining any of the closed groups, please make sure you reach out to the session's host beforehand.

Tuesday 11 June 2025

Session Title	When?	Where?	Contact	Open?
"Team 5"	Tuesday 13:30-15:30	Room 003A	<i>Aleksandra Krstic Dimitra Milioni</i>	no
We will discuss the data collection, methodology, things accomplished so far and future plans regarding our cross-country analysis of MEPs and MPs expression of opinions on X, Facebook and Instagram.				
Computational Literacy	Tuesday 13:30-15:30	Room 003B	<i>Ema Kristo, Edlira Gugu David Herrero Blanco Carlos Arcila Calderón</i>	yes
We plan to conduct a series of interviews as part of our project on the adoption and use of AI tools and computational literacy among opinion researchers. Our interview questionnaire is designed to understand the factors influencing opinion researchers' adoption and use of computational methods. Our goal is to gather insights into the experiences, perceptions, and the supportive environment regarding the use of these technologies in opinion research.				
Measuring "opinions" of generative LLMs with association tasks	Tuesday 13:30-15:30	Room 004	<i>Aleksandra Urman Johannes B. Gruber Valerie Hase</i>	yes
In this session, we will present our project idea of using association tasks to measure stereotyping and bias in generative LLMs across different linguistic and national contexts. We want to use the project slot to invite other OPINION network members interested in the topic to collaborate, so we envision the session as a space for brainstorming and project initialization. The slot is open to all OPINION network members.				
Hackathon Planning Meeting	Tuesday 13:30-15:30	Room 005	<i>Christian Baden</i>	yes
In this meeting, we will discuss how to plan and organize an OPINION Hackathon to take place in conjunction with the ECREA European Communication Conference in Ljubljana. Anyone willing to contribute to the planning is welcome to join.				
Open Space	Tuesday 13:30-15:30			yes
Additional free spaces are kept available for any ad hoc or new project collaboration meetings that may arise - feel free to discuss new ideas and initiatives!				

Tuesday 11 June 2025

Session Title	When?	Where?	Contact	Open?
Theorizing Public Opinion in Digital Media	Wednesday 14:30-16:00	Room 003A	<i>Christian Baden</i>	no
We are preparing a theoretical conference paper and article discussing what it means to study public opinion as a discursive process that takes place on digital media. The paper aims to make both theoretical and operational recommendations to computational public opinion researchers.				
Research Workshop: Evaluation of LLMs as a Tool for Text Analysis	Wednesday 14:30-16:00	Room 003B	<i>Ljubisa Bojic Anela Mulahmetovic Ibr. Selma Veseljevic Jerkov.</i>	yes

The workshop is meant to compare the text analysis capabilities of LLMs with the qualitative analysis performed by humans through the triple rating procedure. The aim is to either confirm or deny hypotheses indicating high similarity between human and machine analysis. By joining our workshop and helping us with a quick analysis of short texts you would deserve co-authorship of the paper. You would also learn how to prompt LLMs to achieve best results in text analysis. Prior to joining all workshop participants would be asked for their informed consent. As for the number of participants we expect 20 people, but there are no limits. However, it is required that you bring your laptop. This Research Workshop is open to anyone who is interested.

Linguistics Group	Wednesday 14:30-16:00	Room 004	<i>Barbara Lewandowska Tomaszczyk</i>	yes
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We're going to discuss ongoing and new projects, in particular (coordinators in brackets) on Misgendering (Jurate Ruzaitė), Opinion change (Barbara Lewandowska Tomaszczyk, Chaya Liebeskind), AI Fact-Opinion types identification (Chaya, Barbara). There are a few papers in preparation, as well as upcoming journal issues, talks and conferences to discuss. Finally, we will discuss final versions of the Glossary and WG1 Literature review.

How to study public opinion in a digitalized world? Conceptualizations - Methods - Techniques	Wednesday 14:30-16:00	Room 005	<i>Agnieszka Hess Elena Negrea Busuioc Agnieszka Stepinska</i>	no
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The project's particular interest is to answer the question of how experts categorize and measure public opinion in the age of digital communication tools and artificial intelligence. The first step of the project will be a survey of COST Action CA21129 participants, who are involved in/conducting public opinion research. In the second stage, team members will conduct in-depth interviews with three expert groups: academia, think tanks and public opinion research centers. The aim of the Salamanca meeting will be to conceptualize the survey tool for the first stage of the planned project activities. The meeting will be attended by those who have declared their participation in the project (Jagiellonian University grant application).

Open Space	Wednesday 14:30-16:00			yes
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Additional free spaces are kept available for any ad hoc or new project collaboration meetings that may arise - feel free to discuss new ideas and initiatives!

Coffee & Lunch

Coffee, tea, juice and water will be offered during breaks in the program.

We will organize lunch for everyone on Tuesday and Wednesday at the Café Restaurant of the adjacent Faculty of Law.

As per COST rules, participants are expected to cover the cost of lunch out of their daily allowance.

Dinner

Each Working Group will organize a joint dinner on Tuesday evening.

The joint WG dinners are voluntary and self-paid, as the costs for dinner are included in the daily allowance. You are obviously welcome to join multiple WG dinners if you are a member of multiple WGs. Please do not forget to sign up through your WGs!

If you don't wish to join these dinner options, we encourage you to find some other network members and mingle at your own discretion. There are many nice restaurants and bistros nearby the meeting venue.

5 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: After the meeting

Reimbursement

According to COST rules, all reimbursements will be processed after the meeting.

We can reimburse only participants who:

- a) were invited to physically attend the meeting, eligible to be reimbursed;
- b) confirmed their attendance via the eCOST system prior to the meeting;
- c) actually attended the network meeting, as documented by signing the attendance lists available at each session;
- d) submitted their reimbursement claims within 14 days after the meeting, via the eCOST system (you will receive an email once the meeting has ended).

Any long-distance travel costs (>100km) will be reimbursed at the value stated on presented tickets, up to a maximum of 1,500 Euro. Participants are expected to book well in time, as soon as you have received your formal invitation (so please avoid last minute bookings) and use economic connections (within reason, nobody expects you to take a train in the middle of the night or fly with three layovers), and book well in time to avoid unnecessary costs. You may include a cancellation insurance, the costs for which will be refunded as part of the ticket. If you use a private car for part of the way, costs are covered at 0.35 EUR/km, up to 2000 km - but please then make sure to keep some documentation of the time line of this part of the trip.

You can also claim expenses for visa processing fees if you needed to obtain a visa specifically for attending the network meeting. Such costs will be reimbursed at the value stated on presented receipts or documentation. This does not include any costs related to visa obtained for purposes beyond the network meeting.

All (!) other costs (i.e., accommodation, local transportation <100km, food etc.) are covered by a flat daily allowance, which for Spain amounts to 192 Euro per full day. The daily allowance takes into account your actual travel time from and to your place of origin, not only the day of the event itself. For instance, if you travel to Salamanca on Monday afternoon and return on Wednesday night, you will be eligible for roughly

two and a half days' worth of daily allowance, or three if you arrive at home only in the next morning.

Please note: All participants that take part also in the Management Committee Meeting and/or the COpA Training School need to submit all their travel costs for reimbursement only ONCE, via the reimbursement claim link for the WG Meeting only. If you attend the Training School you will receive daily allowance for the additional days spent in Salamanca, obviously.

Please note that we will, however, not disburse daily allowances for the time that you spent traveling for reasons unrelated to the network meeting and/or the Training School: If you put in additional days in Spain for your own reasons, that's up to you, but we will then only consider the time that you would have spent traveling without such intermissions toward your daily allowance.

Please note also that, if you arrive from or continue to a destination other than your home institution, we will ask you to explain that in your reimbursement claim. If you travel to multiple destinations, we will only refund your travel costs from the preceding and to the next destination, and assume that any other legs of your trip are motivated by other purposes and covered otherwise. You are required to avoid double funding. Claiming reimbursement for expenses that are covered by other sources will be considered a violation of COST rules.

For the full COST rules on travel reimbursements, please consult this document: https://www.cost.eu/travel_reimbursement_rules

Also note that it is your responsibility to keep your bank contact data in your COST profile up to date, and to submit your receipts and refund claims within two weeks after the meeting.

Minutes & Recordings

All minutes and recordings of the Working Group meeting, concerning both the plenary sessions and the Working Group sessions, will be made available to all members, including those who did not participate in person, within two weeks after the meeting.

6 PARTICIPANTS

The fourth joint Working Group meeting of the OPINION COST Network includes a total of 61 participants from 23 countries who will participate in person. The entire network presently comprises 200 members from 40 countries.

Name	Surname	Institution	Country	WG1	WG2	WG3	WG4	MC
Kinga	Adamczewska	Adam Mickiewicz U Poznan	Poland		◆	◆		
Carlos	Arcila Calderón	U of Salamanca	Spain		◆		◆	◆
Anna	Baczowska	U Gdansk	Poland	◆	◆			
Christian	Baden	The Hebrew U of Jerusalem	Israel	◆			◆	◆
Snezana	Bajceta	U of Belgrade	Serbia		◆			
Malgorzata	Bielenia	U Gdansk	Poland				◆	
Magdalena	Bielenia- Grajewska	U Gdansk	Poland	◆		◆		
David	Blanco-Herrero	U of Salamanca	Spain		◆		◆	
Ljubisa	Bojic	U of Belgrade	Serbia				◆	
Hajo	Boomgaarden	U of Vienna	Austria			◆		
Anita	Ciunova- Shuleska	Cyril & Methodius U in Skopje	North Macedonia	◆				
Nicoleta	Corbu	National U of Political Studies & Public Admin.	Romania	◆	◆			◆
Bruno	Costa	U of Beira Interior	Portugal	◆			◆	◆
Alona	Dolinsky	VU Amsterdam	Netherlands			◆		
Emese	Domahidi	TU Ilmenau	Germany			◆		◆
Jelena	Gledic	U of Belgrade	Serbia		◆		◆	
Roksana	Gloc	U Krakow	Poland		◆			
Johannes B.	Gruber	Vrije U Amsterdam	Netherlands		◆		◆	
Edlira	Gugu	U of Elbasan	Albania		◆		◆	◆

Dana	Guy	U College Dublin	Ireland			◆	◆	
Valerie	Hase	LMU Munich	Germany		◆			
Alba	Haveriku	Polytechnic U of Tirana	Albania		◆	◆		
Agnieszka	Hess	Jagiellonian U	Poland	◆	◆			◆
Mirjana	Ilic	U of Niš	Serbia	◆	◆			◆
Tonja	Jerele	U of Ljubljana	Slovenia		◆			
Ana	Jovančević	U of Niš	Serbia			◆	◆	
Ledia	Kazazi	U of Elbasan	Albania	◆		◆		
Nelda	Kote	Polytechnic U of Tirana	Albania		◆	◆		
Ema	Kristo	U of Tirana	Albania		◆		◆	
Aleksandra	Krstic	U of Belgrade	Serbia	◆			◆	◆
Tamara	Kunić	Faculty of Croatia Studies	Croatia	◆			◆	◆
Ana Ines	Langer	U of Glasgow	United Kingdom		◆		◆	
Barbara	Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk	State U of Applied Sciences	Poland	◆	◆			
Artur	Lipiński	Adam Mickiewicz U Poznan	Poland	◆	◆			
Michaela	Maier	RPTU Kaiserslautern-Landau	Germany		◆			
Jaromir	Mazak	STEM Ústav empirických výzkumů	Czechia			◆		◆
Dimitra	Milioni	Cyprus U of Technology	Cyprus	◆				◆
Ana	Milojevic	U of Belgrade	Serbia	◆			◆	
Larisa	Mistrean	Academy of Economic Studies of Moldova	Moldova			◆	◆	◆
Anela	Mulahmetović Ibrišimović	U of Tuzla	Bosnia and Hercegovina			◆	◆	◆
Elena	Negrea Busuioc	National U of Political Studies & Public Admin.	Romania	◆				
Nuran	Öksüz	Yeditepe U	Turkey			◆	◆	
Alper	Özkan	Kırklareli U	Turkey			◆		

şule Yüksel	Özmen	Trabzon U	Turkey	◆				
Nikolina	Palamidovska-Sterjadovska	Cyril & Methodius U in Skopje	North Macedonia	◆				
Nenad	Pantelic	U of Kragujevac	Serbia			◆	◆	
Marina	Popescu	Median Research Center	Romania	◆		◆		◆
Ardita	Reçi	RTSh Albanian Public Broadcaster	Albania	◆				
Jana	Rosenfeldova	Charles U Prague	Czechia	◆			◆	
José	Santana Pereira	Lisbon U Institute	Portugal	◆				
Serghei	Sprincean	Academy of Science of Moldova	Moldova			◆	◆	
Nina	Springer	U of Münster	Germany	◆		◆		
Agnieszka	Stepinska	Adam Mickiewicz U Poznan	Poland	◆				◆
Aleksandar	Tomasevic	U of Novi Sad	Serbia		◆	◆		
Damian	Trilling	U of Amsterdam	Netherlands		◆			◆
Aleksandra	Urman	U of Zurich	Switzerland		◆		◆	◆
Mariken	van der Velden	Vrije U Amsterdam	Netherlands				◆	
Selma	Veseljević Jerković	U of Tuzla	Bosnia and Hercegovina			◆	◆	◆
Srdjan	Vesic	CRIL	France		◆			◆
Lenka	Vochocová	Charles U Prague	Czechia	◆			◆	◆
Vuk	Vukovic	U of Montenegro	Montenegro	◆			◆	◆
Bruno	Yun	U of Aberdeen	United Kingdom		◆			

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COST (European Cooperation in Science and Technology) is a funding agency for research and innovation networks. Our Actions help connect research initiatives across Europe and enable scientists to grow their ideas by sharing them with their peers. This boosts their research, career and innovation.